

State of Alaska – Office of the Governor — 34th Alaska State Legislature – Second Session
DEPARTMENT REVIEW – PASSED LEGISLATION

BLUE SHEET

Blue Sheets are a department's final bill analysis and provides the Commissioner an opportunity to weigh in on legislation that has passed, with a recommendation to the Governor on action that may be taken– to enact the bill, to veto the bill, or to allow the bill to become Law without signature (LWOS). Much of the information requested in the Blue Sheet can be taken from the department's bill analyses (BA), which were initially submitted at the time the bill was introduced and updated throughout the legislative process.

Blue sheets are due to the GLO three days after the enrolled bill appears on basis, or sooner by request.

Department: DEED

Date: 5/17/2026

Bill Number: SB 23

Short Title (as it appears on BASIS): Civics Education

What action do you recommend the Governor take?

Select one.

☒ **SIGN** ☐ **VETO** ☐ **LWOS**

Action Justification – Why do you recommend the above action?

Please be specific.

Senate Bill 23 is an important investment in Alaska's future because it strengthens civic education and prepares students to become informed, engaged, and responsible citizens. By creating a consistent statewide framework for civics and comparative government instruction, the bill ensures students gain a strong understanding of constitutional principles, government structures, civic responsibilities, and participation in public life. The legislation also provides multiple pathways for students to demonstrate civic competency and recognizes exceptional achievement through the Seal of Civic Readiness.

Additionally, the inclusion of comparative systems of government, including Alaska Native governance systems, reflects Alaska's unique cultural and governmental landscape while promoting a broader understanding of civic engagement. This approach also aligns with the Governor's Tribal Compact initiative by recognizing the importance of tribal governance and encouraging greater understanding of Alaska Native leadership and governmental systems. Senate Bill 23 will help equip the next generation of Alaskans with the knowledge and skills necessary to participate thoughtfully and responsibly in their communities and democratic institutions, and for these reasons, the Governor should sign this legislation into law.

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While working with the sponsor of the bill, the bill if becomes law, would utilize preexisting curriculum and would be a zero cost to the department.

What does this Bill do?

In addition to providing a succinct bill summary, please also consider the following: Why is this bill needed? How does it specifically change department programs? What is the anticipated impact on the public, the private sector? Does this bill align with the priorities of Governor Dunleavy?

This bill seeks to amend education law to add comparative government and civics education, assessment, and secondary school graduation requirements. This bill advocates for 1) the development and periodic review of a statewide civics, semester long course in civics and comparative government, 2) the development of 100 question civic assessment based on the civics portion of the naturalization examination used by the United States Citizenship and Immigration Services of the Department of Homeland Security, 3) the development of a civics project-based assessment, 4) the development of regulations to identify students who have attained a high level of proficiency in civic knowledge, civic skills, a civic mindset, and civic experiences, 5) creation of a seal of civic readiness that may be attached to a student's school transcript and diploma. Students must complete the required course or receive a passing score of 70 percent or more on one of the assessments in order to receive a secondary school diploma.

Detailed Sectional Analysis

The full sectional analysis of the bill should be completed by the lead agency. Other departments should include an analysis for sections of the bill affecting their agencies.

Section 1: AS 14.03 is amended by adding section 14.03.076. Comparative government and civics curriculum and assessments requirement. This section requires the State Board of Education to develop and periodically review a statewide comparative government and civics education curriculum, civics assessment, and civics project-based assessment.

The curriculum developed under this statute would require the inclusion of the following topics:

- 1) the founding of the United States, including foundational documents and the principles of government of the United States;
- 2) federalism, including the role and operations of local, state, and national governments;
- 3) the institutions of the United States government, including the responsibilities of the executive, legislative, and judicial branches;
- 4) the rights and responsibilities of United States citizenship;
- 5) civil liberties and civil rights;
- 6) the Constitution of the State of Alaska and the Constitution of the United States;
- 7) political parties and interest groups;
- 8) campaigns and elections;
- 9) the United States Congress;
- 10) domestic policy;
- 11) foreign policy;
- 12) comparative systems of governments used globally and by Alaska Natives;

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- 13) international relations; and
- 14) major issues facing local, state, and the United States governments.

This section provides provision for students to receive their diploma if they 1) achieve a passing score on the civics assessment, or achieved a passing score on a similar test in the previous five years; 2) achieved a passing score on the developed civics project-based assessment, or has achieved a passing score on a similar civics project-based assessment while in high school; a student with a disability who receives a waiver from the governing body; or 4) the student has transferred into a state public school after having completed grade 10 or has successfully completed a high school state history course from another state.

This section requires that the passing of the civics assessment be documented on the student's transcript and that the student may retake the assessment, as needed, to achieve a passing score.

This section also requires the department to adopt regulations to recognize high achievement in civic knowledge, civic skills, a civic mindset, and civic experiences. High achievement will be recognized through a state seal of civic readiness affixed to the student's transcript and diploma.

This section defines a "passing score" having been met by a student having answered correctly 70 percent or more of the questions on a civics' assessment, or having received a score of 70 percent or higher on a civics project-based assessment.

Section 2: This section defines the transition for implementation of the act, applying the graduation requirement to students entering grade nine on or after July 1, 2026.

Section 3: This act takes effect July 1, 2026

Companion or Similar Bills

Please note companion legislation, the sponsor of the companion legislation, and identify any "rider" bills or provisions from other legislation that was included in this final bill. Please include the name of the sponsor of the "rider bill" or provision. If it was added as an amendment in a committee – please indicate the name of the legislator that sponsored the amendment.

None

Support/Opposition of the Bill

Please identify names, organizations, titles, and phones numbers of those who testified in support or in opposition of this bill.

Support

Dr Shawn Healy, iCivics

Dr Cyndy Myka, Kodiak Superintendent

Susan Nedza, Hoonah City School District Superintendent

Bill Signing ceremony suggestions (if applicable)

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Please provide information for consideration for a bill signing ceremony. Information that is helpful includes: a specific conference, event, venue, date, and the names and contact information of stakeholders who should be considered for an invitation to the bill signing ceremony.

Not Applicable

Commissioner's Signature:  Date: 5/19/2026

I have reviewed the above information and provided it to the Governor's Legislative Office for consideration of an action by the Governor on legislation passed during the second session of the 34th Alaska State Legislature.

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